



THOUSAND
SERVER

THOUSAND SERVER /SUPPORT A/I

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NINETEEN DAYS BEFORE THE DEADLINE,
AUTISTICI/INVENTATI IS SHUTTING DOWN



THE ITALIAN COMMUNICATIONS COLLECTIVE SURVIVED
RAIDS, SURVEILLANCE AND SERVER SEIZURES FOR 25
YEARS. ELEVEN DAYS AFTER THE UNITED STATES
DESIGNATED IT A GLOBAL TERRORIST ORGANIZATION, AI
SAYS THE RISK TO ITS USERS HAS BECOME TOO GREAT
TO CONTINUE

Autistici/Inventati is shutting down. On September 6, eleven days after the United States placed the Italian technology collective on its terrorism sanctions list, A/I announced that the collective itself will close and that the email, blogging, hosting and communications services it has provided for a quarter century will soon be discontinued. "A/I is shutting down," the collective wrote. "The Autistici/Inventati collective is shutting down and will soon discontinue all of the services we provide." The announcement turns what had been a developing fight over sanctions, infrastructure and political speech into something considerably more concrete. Twenty-five years of independent communications infrastructure are being dismantled.

And A/I says plainly why. The collective said continuing to operate now risks exposing its users, collaborators and communities to legal and financial consequences simply because they interact with an organization the United States has designated a Specially Designated Global Terrorist. "The possibility that our work may cause legal and financial consequences to those who are close to us," A/I wrote, "leaves us no choice." The shutdown comes nineteen days before the expiration of the temporary wind-down period the U.S. Treasury Department created when it sanctioned A/I. That deadline is September 25. A/I did not make it there.



ELEVEN DAYS

On August 26, the Treasury Department's Office of Foreign Assets Control added Autistici/Inventati to its Specially Designated Nationals and Blocked Persons List under Executive Order 13224. Treasury accused A/I of supplying "specialized digital architecture, tools, and services" to what the department described as Antifa cells and other violent far-left organizations. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the government would bring the "full weight" of its economic tools against what it called their enablers and continue cutting their financial lifelines "until they are eliminated."

Eleven days later, one of the organizations named in that announcement said it could no longer safely exist.

The United States did not issue an order instructing Autistici/Inventati to turn off its servers. That distinction matters. It also does remarkably little to soften what happened. Economic sanctions operate through banks, registrars, payment processors, hosting companies and other intermediaries that suddenly have their own reasons to sever ordinary relationships with a designated entity. Washington does not necessarily need to seize a server when it can make everybody touching the

server afraid to keep touching it.

A/I's September 6 announcement describes precisely that pressure. The collective says the danger now extends beyond itself to users and people who merely "have something to do with us." Every additional relationship becomes another possible point of exposure. In other words, the pressure does not stop at the sanctioned organization. It radiates outward until isolation becomes the rational response.

The wind-down that wasn't

OFAC simultaneously issued Counter Terrorism General License 36 when it designated A/I, temporarily authorizing transactions ordinarily necessary to wind down relationships involving the collective. The authorization runs through September 25. On paper, that provided roughly one month for an orderly retreat. Reality moved considerably faster.

Within days of the designation, autistici.org became unreachable through ordinary DNS resolution. A/I continued trying to keep its infrastructure accessible



and its users informed. Now, in announcing its closure, the collective itself warns that similar disruptions may happen again without warning before users can complete their migrations. It says instructions for backing up blogs, mailboxes and websites are coming, but it cannot guarantee what parts of its infrastructure will remain reachable in the meantime.

This is what “wind-down” looks like outside Treasury's vocabulary. People scrambling to recover years of email. Blogs needing emergency backups. Websites looking for somewhere else to live. Administrators spending their remaining time evacuating an infrastructure instead of maintaining it. The machinery is administrative. The consequences aren't.

From “we will resist” to shutdown

A/I's own description of the last eleven days is worth dwelling on. When the designation arrived, the collective says it intended to resist for as long as resistance remained possible. It had spent years maintaining what it calls “free, privacy-friendly, autonomous and politically committed infrastructure.” But by September 6, it concluded that continuing to provide those services was incompatible with protecting the people who used them.

“Every day we stayed online after August 26, 2026, has been a victory,” A/I wrote. But it would not demand martyrdom from itself or its users. Continuing to operate, it said, now endangered the same communities the infrastructure was created to protect. “Under these circumstances, we are no longer able to maintain our original mission,” the collective concluded.

That distinction is crucial. A/I is not announcing that its technology failed. Its servers did not collectively explode. Twenty-five years of technical knowledge did not suddenly evaporate. It is shutting down because maintaining the infrastructure has itself become dangerous.

What is disappearing

Autistici/Inventati began in 2001 out of Italy's hacklab, autonomous media and radical technology cultures. Over twenty-



five years it built and maintained noncommercial communications infrastructure including email, mailing lists, websites, chat systems, publishing tools and Noblogs. Its model was deliberately unlike the corporate Internet: collect as little information as possible, refuse to turn communication into a commodity, and give politically active communities infrastructure that did not require Google, Meta or Microsoft to sit between them and one another.

That philosophy repeatedly brought A/I into conflict with authorities. It survived surveillance, server seizures and infrastructure compromise. Those experiences helped produce Plan R*, a distributed architecture built around the assumption that servers themselves could be seized or compromised.

A quarter century of engineering around hostile machines and hostile governments ultimately encountered another attack surface: the financial and legal relationships surrounding the machines.

You can distribute servers. Distributing the international banking system is trickier.

So who's next?

That is no longer a hysterical question.

Treasury's case against A/I matters because the department did not describe an organization whose principal public function was carrying out attacks. It repeatedly described infrastructure: digital architecture, technological tools, communications and services. The government says providing that infrastructure to particular organizations made A/I a sanctionable enabler.

Take that theory seriously for a moment and an uncomfortable amount of the Internet comes into view.

Autonomous email providers. Privacy-oriented hosting collectives. Federated social networks. VPN providers. Encrypted messaging services. Domain registrars willing to host controversial organizations. Independent media infrastructure. Donation processors. File-sharing systems. Organizations maintaining Tor relays or other privacy infrastructure. Any service whose users include movements the executive branch decides to characterize as terrorist-linked suddenly has reason to ask where infrastructure ends and "support" begins.

Services closer to A/I's political and technical model would obviously face that uncertainty first. A small autonomous host does not have Meta's legal department, billions of dollars, armies of lobbyists or enough market power to make half of Washington answer the phone. That disparity is part of the story. A sanctions architecture does not strike every intermediary equally. It lands hardest on the infrastructure least capable of surviving the compliance panic it creates.

But Meta is useful precisely because it exposes the problem with the principle.

People accused or convicted of terrorism have used Facebook. Extremist organizations have attempted to organize through Instagram. Federal prosecutions routinely describe defendants communicating through mainstream platforms. DOJ itself recently described alleged conspirators using Signal, SimpleX, Discord, TikTok and Instagram while planning an attack. Nobody seriously argues that the existence of those communications automatically turns every company carrying them into a terrorist organization.

Why not?

Because until now we have generally understood that providing infrastructure is not the same thing as adopting every purpose of every person using it.

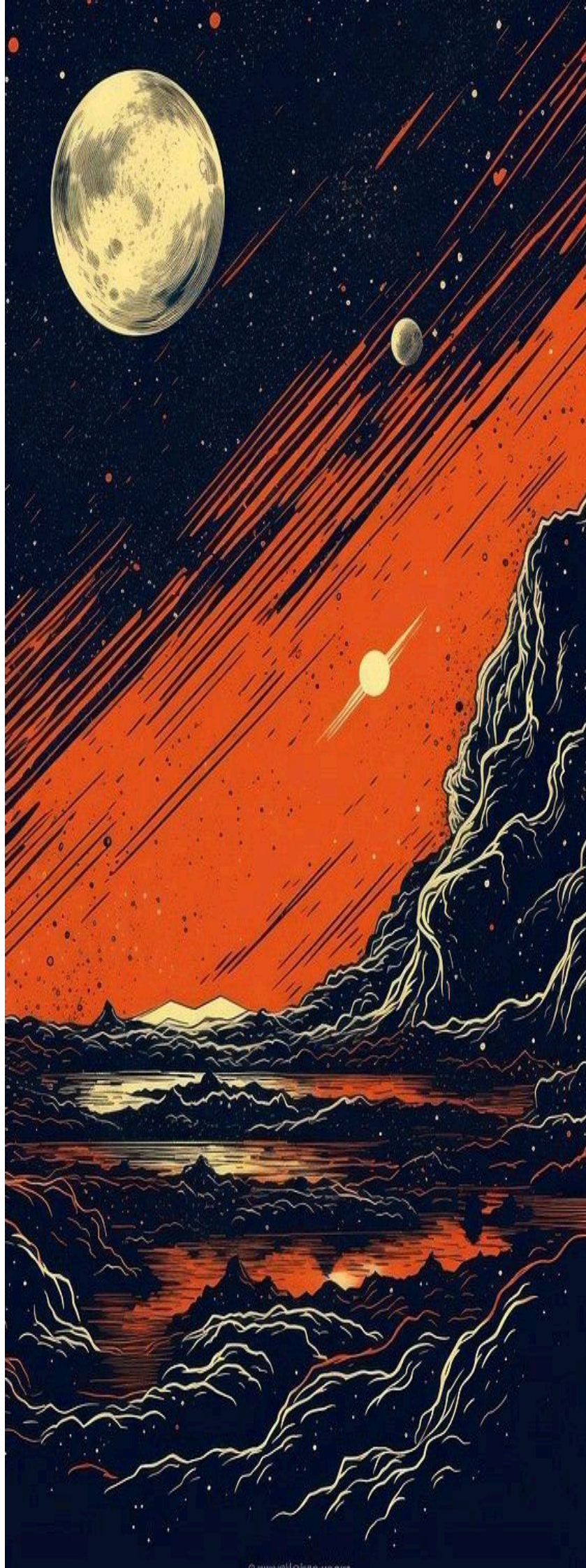
A postal service carries letters without becoming part of every conspiracy described inside an envelope. A telephone company transmits conversations without becoming a participant in every crime discussed over the phone. A hosting provider can carry a website without authoring it. An encrypted messenger can transmit a conversation without knowing what it says.

The Internet depends on those distinctions.

The A/I designation puts pressure directly on them.

And once the executive branch can characterize politically committed technological infrastructure as an “enabler,” the practical question becomes less can this logic reach another provider? than which providers will the government choose to apply it to?

That is where the Trump administration's wider campaign against “Antifa” becomes impossible to separate from this story. The White House says Trump directed the federal government to “hunt down, disrupt, and dismantle” what it calls the Antifa network. DOJ has increasingly used terrorism language in prosecutions involving



alleged Antifa-affiliated defendants. Treasury has now extended that campaign beyond people accused of violence and into the communications infrastructure the government says supports them.

That is an escalation.

Could they really do this to Meta?

Not in the simple sense that a president can wake up annoyed with Mark Zuckerberg, scribble “terrorist” on a napkin and switch Facebook off before breakfast. American companies have constitutional protections, statutory rights, enormous resources and avenues for judicial review. Different terrorism authorities also operate under different legal frameworks. Pretending all of those constraints disappear would make the argument easier to knock down.

The more disturbing point is that A/I demonstrates how much damage can occur before the underlying theory receives meaningful judicial scrutiny.

Designation comes first. Compliance departments react. Banks become nervous. Registrars reconsider relationships. Payment processors calculate risk. Vendors leave. Users flee because they cannot afford to discover whether merely interacting with the sanctioned service creates a problem for them. By the time lawyers begin arguing about the limits of executive authority, the infrastructure may already be dead.

A/I lasted eleven days.

That is the precedent worth examining.

Not “Trump can delete any website.”

Something considerably more plausible: the executive branch possesses economic tools powerful enough to make a targeted piece of infrastructure poisonous to much of the commercial system around it, and therefore potentially nonviable, without having to physically confiscate the infrastructure or obtain a criminal conviction against the people running it first.

For a company the size of Meta, resistance could involve years of litigation.



For a volunteer-run autonomous service, there may be nothing left to litigate over by then.

Infrastructure becomes evidence

This is why the designation raises a question considerably larger than one Italian collective: when does providing communications infrastructure become material support?

The government argues that A/I's provision of technological services crossed that line. A/I rejects that characterization and has repeatedly emphasized the distinction between maintaining infrastructure and controlling the actions of everyone who uses it.

That disagreement is now considerably less theoretical.

The provider is closing.

Infrastructure is not politically neutral in some mystical sense, and A/I never pretended to be. It openly describes itself as politically committed. But political commitment and operational responsibility are different things. If that difference collapses, an extraordinarily powerful mechanism appears: a government does not necessarily have to show that infrastructure operators

planned a particular illegal act if their infrastructure can instead be characterized as part of the ecosystem surrounding people accused of committing one.

Then the designation itself starts doing the work.

The chilling effect now has a body count of services

Sanctions arrive wrapped in institutional language: designation, compliance, wind-down, blocked property, secondary sanctions, risk management. The words are clean enough to make the mechanism sound nearly bloodless.

Then people lose email accounts.

Blogs accumulated over decades need emergency backups.

Organizations scramble to migrate websites.

Domains disappear.

Financial relationships become liabilities.

Volunteers spend nights trying to preserve data instead of running services.

People who have nothing to do with violence begin wondering whether keeping an account, accepting a donation, hosting a domain or sending an email exposes them to consequences they do not understand.

And eventually the people maintaining the infrastructure decide that keeping it alive presents too much risk to everybody around them.

That is the material effect.

A/I's shutdown is therefore not merely another development in the story of its designation.

It is evidence of what the designation does.

A deadline Washington didn't need

When OFAC issued General License 36, September 25 appeared to be the important date. Sabot's reporting has followed that deadline because it represented the endpoint of Treasury's temporary authorization for winding down certain transactions involving A/I.

September 25 may now be less important than September 6.

The pressure worked faster than the calendar.

The designation came August 26. Infrastructure disruption followed. Legal and financial risk spread outward toward users and anyone maintaining relationships with A/I. Eleven days later, and nineteen days before Treasury's wind-down period expires, the collective concluded that remaining online was too dangerous.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on August 26 that the government would bring the full weight of its economic tools against the organizations it identified and continue cutting their financial lifelines "until they are eliminated."

Eleven days later, Autistici/Inventati announced that it was eliminating itself.

The government did not have to send agents into a server room.

It did not have to obtain a criminal conviction against A/I's administrators.

It did not even have to wait for its own September 25 deadline.

Become the thousand servers

There will be technical questions in the coming days. A/I says it will publish instructions explaining how users can preserve blogs, mailboxes and websites, while warning that further disruptions may arrive without notice. Those instructions matter. So does preserving a record of what happened here.

But preservation cannot be the end of the response.

For too long, autonomous infrastructure has been treated as a specialist concern, something for the nerds in the basement while everybody else gets on with the supposedly more important work of organizing, publishing, feeding people, defending communities and building movements.

That distinction has become untenable.

If you organize people, you need to understand where your communications live. If you publish radical journalism, you need to know who controls your infrastructure. If you run a mutual-aid project, legal-defense fund, abolitionist organization, labor project or community space, somebody in your world needs to understand domains, backups, servers, encryption and what happens when the corporation providing those things decides that keeping you as a customer has become inconvenient.

Not everybody needs to become a systems administrator. But autonomous movements cannot continue outsourcing almost all of their technical existence to a handful of exhausted collectives and enormous corporations and then discover the architecture underneath them only when somebody starts pulling plugs.

A/I spent twenty-five years building one answer to that problem.

Now we need a thousand.

A thousand servers does not literally mean a thousand identical machines humming under anarchists' kitchen tables, although there are worse uses for a kitchen table. It means redundancy.



Federation. Shared knowledge.
Community hosting. Independent
email. Mirrors. Backups. Small
providers. Regional
infrastructure. People
teaching other people how
the machinery works until
the disappearance of any
single project cannot
take an entire piece
of movement
infrastructure with
it.

It means making
technical knowledge
ordinary movement
knowledge.

Learn how to run a
server. Then teach
somebody else.

Learn how DNS works. Learn
what actually happens when
you type a domain into a
browser. Learn where your
organization's email lives, who
controls the account, where the
backups are and how you would move
tomorrow if you had to. Build a
little server for a community
project. Join an existing
autonomous technology
collective. Start one
where none exists.
Federate with others.
Document what you learn
so the next
person
does not
have to
begin from
zero.

Then go forth and multiply.

Because the lesson of A/I is not that autonomous infrastructure failed.

It is that there was not enough of it.

If one autonomous project can be isolated, there should be ten more behind it. If ten can be isolated, there should be a hundred. No single domain, bank, hosting provider, administrator or collective should become a point at twenty-five years infrastructure can to disappear.

We need to become

And this cannot
confined to
MX record is.

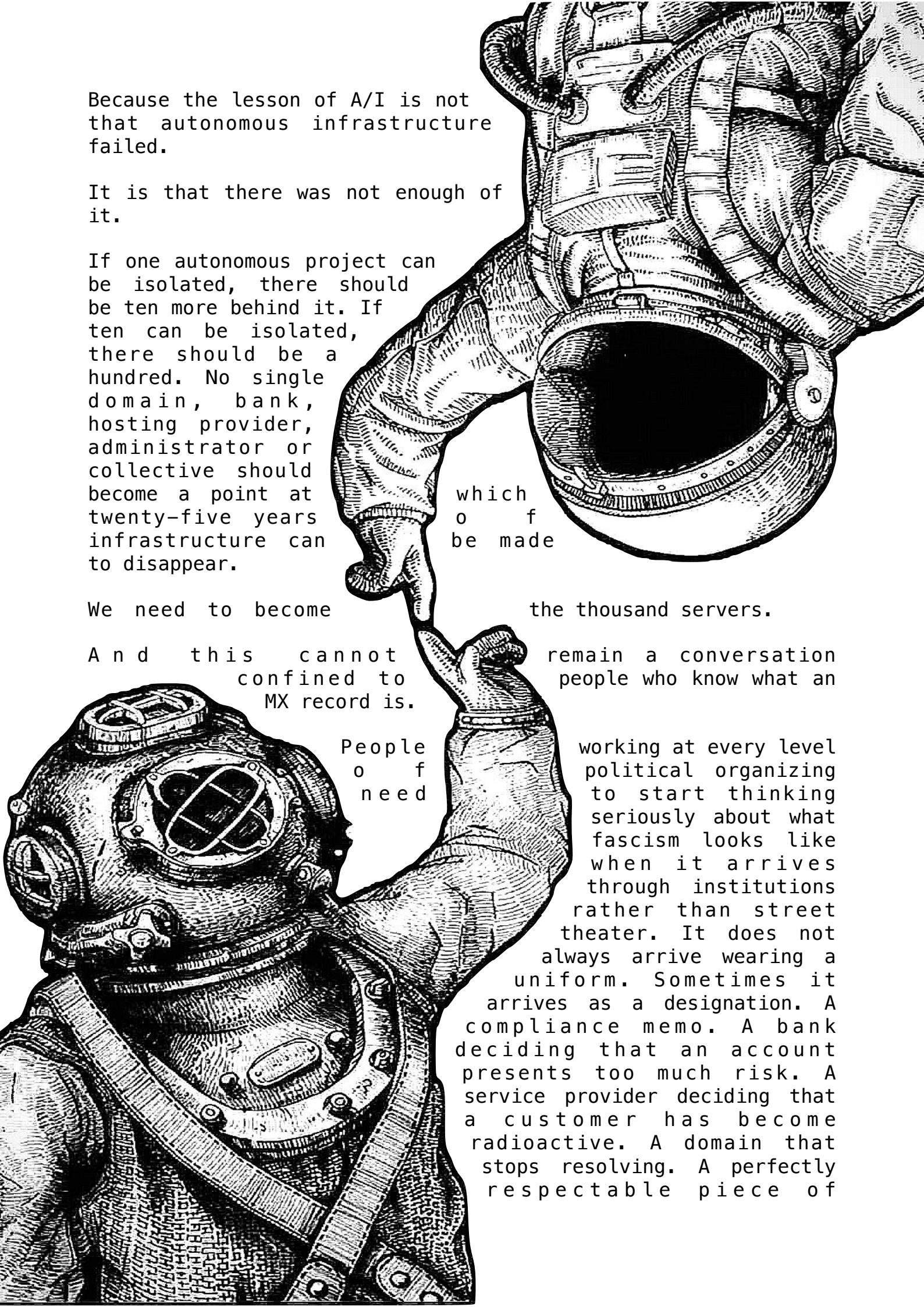
People
o f
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which
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be made

the thousand servers.

remain a conversation
people who know what an

working at every level
political organizing
to start thinking
seriously about what
fascism looks like
when it arrives
through institutions
rather than street
theater. It does not
always arrive wearing a
uniform. Sometimes it
arrives as a designation. A
compliance memo. A bank
deciding that an account
presents too much risk. A
service provider deciding that
a customer has become
radioactive. A domain that
stops resolving. A perfectly
respectable piece of



paperwork that causes everyone downstream to quietly close a door.

That is part of what authoritarian power looks like in a networked society.

It is here.

That statement should not require theatrical predictions about some future moment when fascism finally announces itself with sufficient clarity that everyone can agree to begin resisting it. Waiting for that moment is a spectacularly bad infrastructure strategy. The mechanisms are already visible. A government identifies an enemy, expands the category of people and institutions surrounding that enemy, applies extraordinary powers to the resulting network, and allows fear and private compliance to magnify the effect.

A/I is what that process looks like when it reaches the server room.

And people operating in higher spheres of journalism, organizing, law, philanthropy, academia and civil society need to understand what the technical people have been trying to explain for years: infrastructure is political power.

Who owns the server matters.

Who controls the domain matters.

Who processes the money matters.

Who can terminate the account matters.

Who knows how to rebuild it somewhere else matters.

Autonomy that exists only at the level of rhetoric is not autonomy. If every meeting is organized through corporate infrastructure, every document lives on somebody else's cloud, every donation passes through a handful of processors and every publication depends on a domain and host that can disappear when a compliance department gets nervous, then enormous portions of our supposedly independent political life remain contingent on permission. A/I's closure should therefore produce grief. Twenty-five years of collective labor deserves grief. It should also produce replication.

Take what worked. Study what failed. Preserve the documentation. Fork the software. Teach the skills. Build relationships between



autonomous hosts before the emergency instead of during it. Make infrastructure literacy part of organizer literacy.

Do not build the next A/I. Build enough of them that there can never again be only one.

Because twenty-five years from now, the significant fact should not simply be that an Italian hacker collective once ran an email service called Autistici/Inventati, until the United States placed it on a terrorism blacklist and the legal, technical and financial consequences made continuing too dangerous.

The significant fact should be what happened afterward.

A/I ended its announcement with a request: get away from the computer. Go outside. Struggle. Hug one another. Keep smiling.

"We are stopping," the collective wrote, "but the Resistance and ideas do not stop."

Then that is the assignment.

BECOME THE THOUSAND
SERVERS.